ONE-PAGE SUMMARY

WPP: Where Humans Stay in the Loop

How can WPP Production turn one approved global campaign into hundreds of market and channel assets, with AI doing the repeatable work and people keeping the judgement calls?

1. WHERE WPP STANDS

WPP is cutting costs and rebuilding production while AI tools reshape the agency business.

£4.75bn
Revenue less pass-through costs in the first half of 2026, down 4.7% like for like.

97,388
People at 30 June 2026. A year earlier there were 104,083.

£500m
Annual savings WPP aims for by 2028 under its Elevate28 plan.

5%
Share of income from WPP Production, the unit formed in February 2026.

2. WHERE THE TIME GOES TODAY

In our illustrative case, about half of the elapsed time goes to review, approval and rework.

13 days: planning, making and waiting	15 days: review, approval and rework

One campaign wave of 480 assets (20 markets, 6 channels, 4 versions) takes 28 working days, and about one asset in three is reworked. These days are our assumptions, built to fit a 2026 vendor survey in which 46% of marketers said content gets stuck in review.

3. THREE LANES OF WORK

Sorting tasks shows where AI can help.

Lane 1
AI works under written rules
29%
of hours

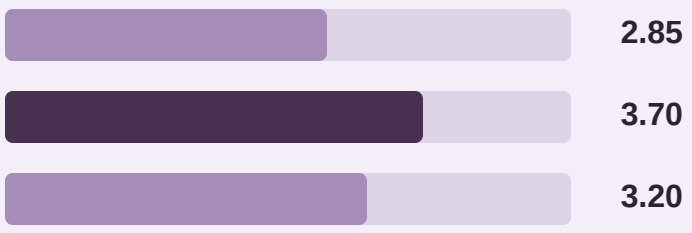
Lane 2
AI drafts, people finish
43%
of hours

Lane 3
People decide
9%
of hours

Rework is the other 19% of hours. Scores are our judgement.

4. THREE OPTIONS SCORED

The redesigned workflow scores highest.



Scores are out of 5. Option C wins only if speed and cost together carry about 60% of the weight, against 40% in the base case.

5. THE RECOMMENDED DESIGN

Four human gates sit around the AI work and bring a wave down to 18 working days.

Set the rules	Prove the pattern	Produce and check	Client approval	Deliver
3 days	3 days	7 days, including 1 of rework	4 days, including 1 of rework	1 day

Gate 1
Brief and brand rules locked

Gate 2
First sample approved

Gate 3
Brand and legal check passed

Gate 4
Client approves the final set

6. WHAT THE MODEL SAYS

The central case saves 27% of the cost per asset and 36% of the elapsed time.

One campaign wave of 480 assets	Cautious	Central	Optimistic
Cost per asset, change	−8%	**−27%**	−50%
Elapsed time, change	−21%	**−36%**	−50%
Months to repay the one-off cost, at 60 waves a year	54	**9.6**	3.9

Time and cost come from different places
About 70% of days saved come from fewer review loops. About 77% of hours saved come from automating repeatable work.

Volume decides whether it pays
At 10 waves a year, even the central case takes about 57 months to repay the one-off cost.

7. RISKS AND CONTROL

The biggest risks

- A brand error could reach the market (15 of 25, falling to 8).
- An unapproved claim or rights problem could slip through (15, falling to 8).
- Clients could refuse sampling (12, falling to 6).

Three rules at each checkpoint

- Continue if time is at least 25% shorter and errors are no higher.
- Re-scope if the saving is 10% to 25%.
- Stop if errors rise, clients reject sampling or the saving is under 10%.

£0.2m **The recommendation is to approve only the first stage now.** It measures today's baseline, writes the rules and chooses a pilot client. Later money, up to an illustrative £1.2m in total, is released only if the stop rules are met.

Independent analysis using public information only. Not affiliated with or endorsed by WPP. All hours, days, costs and probabilities are illustrative assumptions, because WPP does not publish production data, and scores are our judgement. Company facts come from WPP's 2025 and first-half 2026 results announcements, with trade coverage from eMarketer, Adweek, MediaPost and CMOtech listed in the Source Log. The model results are our own calculations.